CREAMY CHEESECAKE

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	REST	TOTAL TIME
1 cake, 23 or 25 cm, 12 to 14 servings	**45 min**	**1 h in the water bath, 1 h at room temperature, then 4 h chilled minimum or**	**about 8 h 30 min, or overnight**

OVEN

350F / 180C for 10 min for the crust, then 325F / 160C for 1 h to 1 h 30 min

INGREDIENTS

1/2 recipe, 150 g once ground	Oat digestive biscuits, fully baked
60 g	Unsalted butter, melted, for the crust
1 tbsp + 1 1/2 tsp	Granulated sugar, for the crust
1/8 tsp	Salt, for the crust
900 g	Cream cheese, at room temperature
250 g	Granulated sugar, for the filling
1/4 tsp	Salt, for the filling
2 tsp	Vanilla extract
2 tsp	Lemon zest
2 tbsp	Lemon juice
4	Eggs, large
2	Egg yolks, large
320 g	Crème fraîche, for the filling
360 g	Crème fraîche, for the topping
1/2 bean	Vanilla bean, split and scraped
3 tbsp	Confectioners' sugar, sifted

METHOD

1. Bake the oat digestive biscuits ahead and let them cool. Half a batch is what you need here.
2. Set a rack at the middle of the oven and heat it to 350F / 180C.
3. Wrap three layers of heavy-duty aluminium foil around the outside of a 23 or 25 cm springform pan, pressing the foil flat to the side and crimping it over the rim. Go over it for holes and gaps, because this is all that stands between the batter and the water bath.
4. Grind the baked biscuits in a food processor with the steel blade until they are fine and sandy. You want 150 g. A sealed bag and a rolling pin will do the same work.
5. Add the melted butter, the crust sugar and the crust salt to the processor and pulse four times. Squeeze a little in your palm — it should look faintly damp and hold its shape.
6. Spoon the crumb into the springform and press it out flat and even with your hands.
7. Bake the crust to golden brown, about 10 minutes, then set it aside to cool. Drop the oven to 325F / 160C.
8. Cube the softened cream cheese into a stand mixer bowl fitted with the paddle. Beat it on medium for 4 minutes, to smooth and creamy, then scrape the bowl down at the sides and the base with a rubber spatula.
9. Add the filling sugar and salt and run the mixer another 4 minutes on medium, scraping the sides and the base again at the halfway mark.
10. Mix in the vanilla extract, the lemon juice and the lemon zest.
11. Break the whole eggs and the yolks together into a jug. With the mixer on low, add them one at a time, scraping between each and letting each disappear fully before the next goes in. Keep the beating gentle here, because a batter full of air cracks in the oven.
12. Stir the filling crème fraîche to break up any lumps. Add it with the mixer on low and run about 1 minute, until the batter is smooth and even throughout. Finish with a stir by hand, reaching the base and sides of the bowl.
13. Pour the batter over the cooled crust and level the top with the back of a spoon or a small spatula.
14. Put a large pot of water on to boil. Stand the springform in the centre of a large roasting pan with tall sides, pull the middle oven rack out a little way, and set the roasting pan on it.
15. Pour boiling water into the roasting pan until it comes halfway up the springform, keeping below the top edge of the foil. Slide the rack back in very gently.
16. Give it 1 hour, then look at it. A gentle nudge should set the middle wobbling while the outer ring stays put. If the centre is still loose and liquid, carry on for up to 30 minutes more, checking at 10 minute intervals.
17. Leave the cake in the water bath to cool for 1 hour, then lift it out of the roasting pan and give it a further hour on the counter. A slight jiggle at the surface is still right at this stage. Unwrap the foil from the pan.
18. Whisk the topping crème fraîche with the confectioners' sugar and the vanilla seeds until smooth and creamy, then spread it over the cake in an even layer.
19. Lay a fresh sheet of foil loosely over the top of the pan and refrigerate at least 4 hours, or overnight.

20. To serve, free the edge with a thin-bladed knife, unclip the ring and lift it away. Move the cake onto a serving plate with a wide metal spatula, or leave it sitting on the pan base.
21. Cut with a knife dipped in warm water and wiped dry. The crust needs a firm hand. Clean the blade between every slice.

NOTES

The staged cooling, an hour in the water and an hour out of it before the long chill, is what gives a smooth top with no cracks.
Air is the enemy once the eggs are in. Overmixing at that point aerates the batter and the bubbles open into cracks as it bakes.
About 10 graham crackers ground to 150 g will stand in for the oat digestive biscuits.
Without a springform, use a high-sided 23 cm cake pan. Line the base with a 23 cm round of parchment and skip the foil. To get it out, run a knife round the edge, invert the pan onto a plate, warm the pan base briefly with a torch or a hair dryer, tap it gently if it holds on, lift the pan away and flip the cake onto a platter.
Well wrapped, it keeps in the refrigerator for up to 1 week.

BASE

Oat Digestive Biscuits

Makes: 24 cookies / Active Time: 25 min / Total Time: about 45 min / Oven: 350F / 180C for 14 min

INGREDIENTS

45 ml	Milk
1 tsp	Molasses
300 g	Rolled oats
80 g	Oat flour
70 g	Dark brown sugar
1 tsp	Salt
1/2 tsp	Baking soda
170 g	Unsalted butter, cold

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F. Line a baking sheet with parchment or a nonstick liner.
2. Stir the milk and molasses together in a small bowl.
3. Cut the butter into 6 mm cubes.
4. In a food processor, grind the rolled oats to a fine meal. Follow with the oat flour, then the brown sugar, the salt and the baking soda, and run it until the mix looks even. Drop in the butter and process to a sandy texture. Pour in the milk and molasses and process just until the dough starts pulling together.
5. By hand, grind the oats fine in a spice grinder or blender. Tip them into a large bowl, add the oat flour, then the brown sugar, the salt and the baking soda, and whisk it all even. Rub the butter in with your fingers until the mixture is sandy. Add the milk and molasses and bring it together with a spatula, stopping as soon as it starts to hold.
6. Turn the dough onto a work surface and knead it a few times into one cohesive mass.
7. Take a tablespoon of dough at a time, roll it into a ball between your palms, and press it flat on the lined sheet. Each disc should end up about 6 mm thick.
8. Bake 7 minutes, turn the sheet around, and bake 7 minutes more, until the bottoms and the edges are golden brown.
9. Let them sit on the sheet 5 minutes, then move them to a wire rack.
10. Keep them in an airtight container at room temperature, where they hold a week.

NOTES

Nothing in the dough is wheat. The structure comes from ground rolled oats plus oat flour, so these are gluten-free if the oats are certified.
A tablespoon of dough per biscuit is what lands the yield at 24. Bigger discs will not bake through in 14 minutes.
The butter goes in cold and is cut or rubbed only to a sandy stage, which is what keeps the texture flaky rather than solid.
300 g of rolled oats against 70 g of sugar puts these on the savory side of a sweet biscuit, and the teaspoon of salt is deliberate.
About 10 of them, 150 g, crumble into a 23 cm gluten-free pie shell or a 25 cm cheesecake base.

DATE ___ / ___ / ___ RATING ___ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

NOTES _____

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